A Modified Newcastle-Ottawa Quality Assessment for Observational Studies

The quality of included studies was assessed using a modified seven-point criteria derived from Newcastle-Ottawa scale (Wells et al., 2000). Each of the following criteria (A to G) was assigned 1 point if met.

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Criteria				
Sample	**Yes**	**No**	**NR**	**Note**
A) Representativeness of the target sample Yes = sampling designed to ensure adequate representativeness No = inappropriately selected sample, or no description of sample selection				
B) Non-response satisfactorily dealt with Yes = comparability between respondent and non-respondent characteristics established and response rate is satisfactory No = the response rate is unsatisfactory, or the comparability between respondents and non-respondents is unsatisfactory, or no description of the response rate or the characteristics of the responders and the non-responders.				
Exposure	**Yes**	**No**	**NR**	**Note**
C) Validated measurement tool Yes = high-resolution ultrasound system with linear ultrasound transducers at frequencies >7 MHz and measurement protocol for cIMT and plaque in accord* with American Society Echocardiography/Mannheim Consensus Guidelines. Data analysis performed independently and blinded using validated analysis system No = inadequate ultrasound system, protocol, or analysis process, or not described				

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D) Relevant confounders measured[†] Yes = sex, age, smoking, hypertension/blood pressure, diabetes, hyperlipidemia/blood lipids/body mass index No = potential confounders not measured or not reported				
Outcome	**Yes**	**No**	**NR**	**Note**
E) Assessment of outcome Yes = independent blinded assessment of cognitive status using a validated instrument No = unvalidated instrument, or not described				
F) Statistical analysis Yes = statistical analysis clearly described and appropriate: estimate of the central tendency of the outcome with a measure of precision is provided (e.g. mean/median (95% confidence interval/standard deviation/range)). No = the statistical analysis is inappropriate, missing or inadequately described				
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Wells, G. et al. (2000) The Newcastle-Ottawa Scale (NOS) for assessing the quality of nonrandomised studies in meta-analyses, Ottawa, ON: Ottawa Hospital Research Institute.

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Outcome	**Yes**	**No**	**NR**	**Note**
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